GLOBAL INTELLIGENCE

Weekly Deep-Dive

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The Week in One Page

- **AI sell-off after the US midterms:** The Nasdaq 100 lost 6.3% on Thursday and the Philadelphia chip index 12.2%. The Nikkei fell 5.96% on Friday. Investors fear a Democratic Congress will bring tougher scrutiny of data centres, though analysts also point to older valuation worries.
- **Democrats win Congress, Trump doubles down:** Democrats took the House, and media projections gave them the Senate. Trump named Stephen Miller chief of staff. Democrats cannot override a veto, so their leverage is investigations and spending.
- **Eurozone inflation hits 4.0%:** Energy inflation is 20.8%, and Italy's rate is 5.6%. The ECB holds at 2.50%, with a December hike openly debated. The Bank of England has already raised to 4.00%.
- **Oil falls 16% on a deal that does not exist:** Brent closed at $98.32 and Dutch gas near €85/MWh on hopes of a US-Iran settlement. Hormuz is still closed, and the hope rests largely on one unnamed diplomat.
- **Two candidates to succeed Lagarde:** Klaas Knot (Netherlands) and Pablo Hernández de Cos (Spain) are the only nominees. Eurogroup ministers review them on 9 November, and EU leaders decide later.
- **Abu Dhabi talks on 10-11 November:** These are the first three-way US-Russia-Ukraine talks since February. Europe is not at the table and fears a US-Russia security deal that weakens NATO.
- **Pro-Russian hackers leak Tajani's data:** Meloni blamed pro-Russian hackers. Interior Minister Piantedosi called a national

security committee for Tuesday. The week also brought bomb hoaxes on flights and freezer hacks in supermarkets.

- **US presses China on the Busan truce:** Washington says Beijing is behind on rare-earth supplies and farm purchases. Trump and Xi are due to meet at APEC in Shenzhen, and China blocked the $5.4bn SoftBank-ABB robotics deal.
- **Houthis hit Riyadh's Aramco Tower:** Riyadh reports limited damage and no casualties. The Houthis say a Saudi strike on Sanaa killed at least 33 people, a claim Riyadh has not commented on. The Yemen war is escalating.
- **Trump says US military aid to Israel ends in 2027:** He says Israel will buy weapons instead. Israel's prime minister's office backed the shift. Congress, which funds the aid, has yet to react.
- **UN mission in Western Sahara ends after 35 years:** A US-Russia impasse at the Security Council left MINURSO without a mandate. Morocco celebrates, and Algeria and the Polisario Front have yet to respond.
- **Paraguay's president removed:** The Senate ousted Santiago Peña after the Ueno Bank collapse, which left about 3 million customers cut off from their money. Vice President Pedro Alliana takes over.

Contents

What It Means for You in Italy 4

Markets Dashboard 5

I. Europe & Italy

Italy 7

European Union 9

Italy in the EU & PNRR 10

Across Europe 12

II. Great Powers

United States 14

China 16

Russia & Ukraine 17

III. World Regions

Middle East & Gulf 19

Indo-Pacific 21

BRICS+ & Global South 22

Africa 23

Latin America 24

IV. Security, Technology & Space

Defence & Security 26

Cyber & Information Warfare 27

Fact Check 29

Technology & AI 30

Space 32

V. Economy, Markets & Energy

Global Economy & Central Banks 34

Markets & Finance 36

Trade, Tariffs & Sanctions 37

Energy & Critical Minerals 39

VI. Analysis & Outlook

How Others See It 41
Trends of the Week 43
Deep Dive 44
Market Implications of the Week 46
Market Opportunities & Risks 47
Scenario Scorecard 48
Explained 49
Week Ahead 50
Glossary 51

What It Means for You in Italy

- **Mortgages and loans:** Markets price roughly an 80-85% chance of an ECB hike to 2.75% on 17 December (market pricing, not a decision). Variable-rate borrowers could see higher instalments in the following months. Fixed-rate borrowers are unaffected.
- **Prices and inflation:** Italy's harmonised inflation is 5.6% (Istat's national index 5.4%), well above the euro-area 4.0%. Wages are rising about 2.5%, so purchasing power keeps shrinking. Final October euro-area data comes on 18 November.
- **Fuel and energy bills:** Brent fell 16% in a week and gas is down from its late-October peak of about €95.7. Pump prices and bills lag, and no deal is signed. Confcommercio says business energy costs are "ever heavier", which feeds through to shop prices.
- **Savings and BTPs:** The ten-year BTP yields about 4.4% and the spread over Germany is about 113 basis points, down from 131 on 1 October. Yields are attractive, but prices fall if rates rise.
- **Pensions and taxes:** The roughly €26bn 2027 budget is in parliament. It trims pension indexation above four times the minimum and raises levies on banks and energy firms. Amendments may still change it.
- **Jobs:** Electrolux job cuts were nearly halved to just over 900. The ex Ilva and Piombino steel sagas remain unresolved.

- **Travel and leisure:** Bomb hoaxes hit scores of European flights this week. Assoutenti says ski passes are up as much as 43% in five years.
- **Cyber risk:** Tajani's leak and the freezer attacks are a security story, not yet a consumer one. Cold-chain firms are under watch.

Markets Dashboard

Europe	Last	Day	Week
Euro Stoxx 50	6,170.49	-0.98%	+0.64%
FTSE MIB (Italy)	50,053.00	-0.90%	+1.12%
DAX (Germany)	25,820.36	-1.92%	+0.01%
CAC 40 (France)	8,139.00	-0.81%	+2.13%
IBEX 35 (Spain)	19,369.50	-0.60%	+3.84%
FTSE 100 (UK)	10,673.90	-1.01%	-0.52%

Americas	Last	Day	Week
S&P 500	7,376.86	+0.31%	-2.68%
Nasdaq 100	26,989.99	+1.35%	-4.91%
VIX (US volatility)	25.64	-9.01%	+32.03%
Bovespa (Brazil)	168,499.00	+1.39%	-0.41%

Asia	Last	Day	Week
Nikkei 225 (Japan)	57,434.77	-5.96%	-11.17%
CSI 300 (China)	4,054.28	–	–
Hang Seng (Hong Kong)	24,481.86	-1.27%	+5.10%
KOSPI (South Korea)	5,059.69	-6.02%	-11.71%
Taiex (Taiwan)	39,701.64	-4.51%	-12.19%
Nifty 50 (India)	24,986.40	-0.18%	+6.59%

Rates	Last	Day	Week
US 10Y yield (%)	4.8590	+0.45%	-1.42%
US 2Y yield (%)	4.7750	+0.00%	+4.42%

Currencies	Last	Day	Week
EUR/USD	1.1228	-0.06%	+0.41%
EUR/GBP	0.8344	+0.09%	-0.17%
EUR/CHF	0.9156	-0.18%	-0.58%
EUR/CNY	7.4142	-1.27%	-0.23%
US Dollar Index (DXY)	102.30	+0.74%	+0.41%
USD/JPY	158.43	+0.59%	+0.47%
USD/CNH	6.6717	–	–
USD/RUB	81.93	+0.53%	+1.55%
USD/INR	93.91	-0.58%	-1.05%
USD/BRL	5.4959	-0.14%	+1.12%
USD/TRY	50.13	-0.04%	+0.34%
Bitcoin ($)	75,870.82	+0.16%	-1.91%

Commodities	Last	Day	Week
Brent ($/bbl)	98.32	+0.03%	-16.42%
WTI ($/bbl)	90.83	+0.34%	-12.76%
Dutch TTF gas (EUR/MWh)	85.59	–	–
Gold ($/oz)	4,074.90	-0.94%	+4.51%
Silver ($/oz)	51.94	-0.56%	+5.79%
Copper ($/lb)	6.2375	-0.18%	-3.42%
Wheat (c/bu)	591.25	-1.34%	-2.03%

Delayed exchange quotes, last daily close (Yahoo Finance). Prices, not policy facts.

I Europe & Italy

Italy

Overall picture: The week was dominated by a cyber incident that reached the foreign minister himself. Alongside it, Italy kept its place in a fragile market and energy backdrop. The BTP-Bund spread, which measures the extra yield Italy pays over Germany, has eased from its early-October peak but remains well above September levels. The 2027 budget bill is moving through parliament. The feed gave little day-by-day detail on the parliamentary stages.

Pro-Russian hackers leak foreign minister Tajani's personal data

On 7 November Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani said hackers had published his personal data online. Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni blamed pro-Russian hackers, according to Bloomberg and the BBC. On 8 November Interior Minister Matteo Piantedosi called the national public-security committee to the Viminale (the Interior Ministry) for Tuesday 10 November to assess the cyber threat.

Why it matters: This is the latest in a run of hybrid attacks (cyber, disinformation, sabotage) on Italy. In February 2026 Tajani said the security services had thwarted Russian-linked attacks on Foreign Ministry sites and on the Milano-Cortina Olympics. The pro-Russian group Noname057(16) claimed some of those attacks. Across Europe this week, scores of flights received bomb hoaxes, and a cyberattack hit the UK meat industry and affected supermarket freezers in several countries. European agencies are probing whether the hoaxes began in Russia. A Russian extremist group has denied sending them.

For Europe & Italy: Rome is treating this as a national-security issue, not just IT. Expect pressure to strengthen the National Cybersecurity Agency (ACN).

Watch: The outcome of Tuesday's Viminale meeting, and whether Italy formally attributes the attack.

Sources: Bloomberg, BBC, ANSA, FT, BBC

Spread near 113 points as ECB warns inflation will stay high

The BTP-Bund spread closed at 113.83 basis points on 3 November, after about 113 the day before. In September it had fallen to roughly 88-89. It then rose above 100 on 30 September and, per ItaliaOggi, touched 131 on 1 October. On 7 November ECB President Christine Lagarde told Japan's Yomiuri Shimbun that inflation will likely stay high in the near term, with second-round effects (wage and price knock-ons) no worse than expected. On 6 November global equities fell on fears of a US AI slowdown, a risk-off move that usually widens spreads.

Market impact: The 10-year BTP yield is around 4.4%. A higher inflation path for longer limits the room for ECB rate cuts. That weighs on Italian debt-servicing costs and on bank margins in different directions.

Watch: The Commission's autumn forecast, traditionally in mid-November, and the final budget votes before year-end.

Sources: Teleborsa, Bloomberg, BBC

Energy costs and prices squeeze business and households

Confcommercio, the retail and services employers' group, warned on 7 November that rising energy bills are hurting service-sector firms and urged cuts in costs. Consumer group Assoutenti said ski-pass prices are up as much as 43% in five years. It says 2 million Italians now forgo a winter-sports week compared with before Covid.

Why it matters: The Commission's spring forecast put 2026 growth at just 0.5%, blaming an energy shock from the war. Energy costs remain the main brake on competitiveness.

Sources: Il Sole 24 Ore, Il Sole 24 Ore

Also this week

- **Exports:** Intesa Sanpaolo's Gregorio De Felice said manufacturing exports rose 53% from 2016 to 2025.
- **Trade fairs:** Ecomondo in Rimini closed on 6 November with international attendance up 14%.

- **Tourism:** Liguria recorded 18.6 million tourist nights in the first nine months, up 3.16%.
- **Tobacco:** The Irish EU presidency proposed new minimum excise duties, with a longer transition for Italy (see the Italy in the EU section).

European Union

Overall picture: The week was about who will lead the ECB after Christine Lagarde, and about Europe's anxiety over a possible US-Russia security deal. Regulation and defence files also moved.

Two candidates to succeed Lagarde at the ECB

The Eurogroup (euro-area finance ministers) closed nominations on Friday 6 November with two names. They are Spain's Pablo Hernández de Cos, who now heads the Bank for International Settlements, and the Netherlands' Klaas Knot, a former Dutch central bank chief. Ministers hold a first review on Monday 9 November. The European Council makes the final appointment. One report says the new president would take office in February. Analysts see Knot as slightly more hawkish, meaning more focused on fighting inflation, and Hernández de Cos as slightly more dovish. They say the differences are modest. A Knot win would require his fellow Dutchman Frank Elderson to leave the ECB board, because there should not be two board members from one country. Japan Times notes a surprise entrant could still appear, as Lagarde did in 2019.

Market impact: Lagarde said on 7 November that inflation will stay high for now. The choice of successor shapes rate expectations for the euro.

Watch: The 9 November Eurogroup, then the leaders' summit.

Sources: Politico Europe, Japan Times, Eunews

Europe uneasy over US plans for a Russia security deal

On 3 November the FT reported that US, UK, EU and NATO officials would meet in Brussels before US talks with Russia and Ukraine in Abu Dhabi, the first since February. The FT and Politico report that European capitals fear a US plan, linked to Jared Kushner, could undermine NATO

and restore a Russian sphere of influence. Russian strikes left 600,000 people without power in eastern Ukraine, and Zelensky called for more sanctions. Politico also reports NATO faces a €7bn shortfall on its military-aid pledge to Kyiv.

Watch: The Abu Dhabi talks, and any EU role in them.

Sources: FT, FT, Politico Europe, Politico Europe

Commission targets TikTok; defence and energy files advance

- **TikTok:** On 6 November the Commission accused TikTok under the Digital Services Act of failing to stop its algorithm pushing users into "rabbit holes" of content on sadness, self-harm and body image.
- **Defence:** The Commission is expected to pick one of two consortia by end-November for a European hypersonic and ballistic interceptor, with a demonstrator targeted for 2030. Britain and France will lead 2,800 troops from 11 nations in a two-week exercise in Poland on deploying a force to Ukraine after the war.
- **Energy:** Member states urged Brussels to sign an electricity-market deal with the UK swiftly.
- **Trade and consumer rules:** France is pressing for a higher fast-fashion levy.

Sources: The Record, Breaking Defense, Defense News, Politico Europe, FT

Climate

The EU's Copernicus service said October was the warmest on record, 1.75C above pre-industrial levels. The FT headline says 2026 is "virtually certain" to exceed 1.5C of average warming. COP31 starts soon in Antalya, Turkey.

Source: FT

Italy in the EU & PNRR

Overall picture: I found no Council or Parliament vote this week in which Italy's position stood out. Italy's exposure was in three places: the ECB succession, a tobacco tax proposal and its fiscal standing.

Tobacco excise: tougher EU rules, more time for Italy

The Irish presidency of the EU Council proposed a new minimum excise duty on tobacco. It would start at 10% of price or €30 per kilo and rise gradually to 50% or €50 per kilo from 2032. It would also tighten rules on purchases from abroad. Il Sole 24 Ore reports Italy would get a longer transition. Tax files need unanimity, so Rome holds a veto and its tobacco industry has leverage.

Watch: The next ECOFIN (finance ministers') discussion of the text.

Source: Il Sole 24 Ore

Fiscal standing and the ECB race

In May the Commission forecast an Italian 2026 deficit of 2.9% of GDP. That is below the 3% ceiling and would let Italy leave the excessive deficit procedure, the EU's corrective track for overspenders. The exit would normally be decided after final 2026 data in spring 2027. The autumn forecast and the Commission's budget opinions are the next checkpoint. Italy has no candidate for the ECB presidency, which is a contest between Spain and the Netherlands.

PNRR tracker

Nothing new moved this week. The Commission is still assessing the final payment request, which Italy sent on 29 September. The Cabina di regia (the government's steering group) had certified all 156 remaining targets on 23 September. Minister Raffaele Foti says the instalment would bring total receipts to €194.4bn.

Item	Status	Next step
10th and last instalment (€28.4bn)	Requested 29 Sept; Commission assessing	Commission opinion, then payment
Targets	156 certified as met (government)	Verification by Commission
Plan revision (June)	€2.1bn shifted to Industria 5.0 and housing	Spending by the end-2026 payment deadline

Sources: Agenzia Nova, Teleborsa, Eunews

Across Europe

Germany

The main story is the presidential succession. Ilse Aigner, the CSU politician who heads the Bavarian parliament, is the de facto candidate for federal president. The SPD has pledged support, and only the CDU's formal vote is missing. Chancellor Friedrich Merz drew criticism for staying silent while backing grew. He pointed to the agreed procedure. The SPD is also in turmoil: Bärbel Bas resigned as co-chair in October, and the party elects its leadership in January. Co-chair and finance minister Lars Klingbeil said he does not "cling to the chair". Politico also reports Bundeswehr plans to station nearly 5,000 soldiers permanently in Lithuania by 2027 under Panzerbrigade 45.

Sources: Handelsblatt, Handelsblatt, Politico Europe

Belgium

Prime Minister Bart De Wever offered the king his resignation on 2 November after his coalition failed to agree the 2027 budget. On 6 November King Philippe refused it and asked him to restart talks. De Wever must report back on 16 November. Reports cite a funding gap of about €10bn by 2029.

Sources: VRT, Euronews

France

Marine Le Pen, the far-right candidate for the 2027 presidential race, briefed ambassadors of France's neighbouring countries over lunch on her EU agenda, Politico reports. Lagarde, asked about a French presidential run, said it is "not in my plans".

Sources: Politico Europe, Il Sole 24 Ore

Poland

Poland will host the two-week exercise led by Britain and France. Drone maker WB Electronics has asked banks to pitch for a possible Warsaw listing next year that could be worth about €7bn.

Sources: Defense News, FT

Spain

Madrid is backing Hernández de Cos for the ECB. Authorities told olive growers to keep 12% of a bumper harvest off the market, the FT reports.

Source: FT

United Kingdom and Norway

Britain's military chief, Sir Richard Knighton, said the UK must "catch up" with Europe in countering Russia and promised more action against Russian submarines in the North Atlantic. A cyberattack on the UK meat industry affected European supermarket freezers. War on the Rocks reports that in spring the UK, Norway and the US disrupted a Russian exercise off Norway simulating an attack on the Svalbard undersea cables.

Sources: FT, BBC, War on the Rocks

Finland

Bank of Finland board member Tuomas Välimäki said on 2 November that the path back to 2% inflation "has become less comfortable".

Source: BIS

II Great Powers

United States

Democrats won control of Congress in Tuesday's midterms. The Associated Press called the House for them early Wednesday, and early reports showed them flipping several Senate seats, with Mississippi and Alaska still uncalled at that point. The new Congress convenes on 3 January. Trump gave mixed messages: he congratulated Democrats while distancing himself from Republican losses.

Trump doubles down: Miller becomes chief of staff

Within two days, Trump replaced Susie Wiles with Stephen Miller, the architect of his immigration policy. Miller takes over on Monday, according to NBC News. Some House Republicans reportedly objected, and Democratic leader Hakeem Jeffries called him a "reckless extremist." On Saturday Trump told supporters, per ANSA, that he will use his veto power and that the MAGA movement will not quit if results disappoint.

Why it matters: Miller's promotion signals confrontation, not accommodation. Bloomberg's analysts note Trump keeps wide unilateral authority over tariffs and executive action. Democrats cannot override a veto without two-thirds majorities. Their leverage is oversight, subpoenas, spending bills and nominations.

Watch: The first investigations in January. The Financial Times reports crypto firms bracing for probes into the Trump family's business ties.

> **Background — tariffs and the courts:** The Supreme Court struck down most of Trump's emergency tariffs earlier this year, according to press reports. Trump has since leaned on other legal authorities, and Miller publicly attacked the justices.

Markets: AI sell-off and a fuel squeeze

Global stocks fell on Friday as fears of tougher scrutiny of data-centre construction and a US AI slowdown spread to Asia and Europe (BBC). Bloomberg describes the AI trade as unravelling after the vote, pushing investors toward Chinese and Indian equities. Separately, the FT reported on 4 November that Trump's diesel arrangement with Russia is faltering. Two tankers changed course while US fuel stocks sit at a 20-year low.

Market impact: US tech and AI-linked shares are the epicentre of the fall. Fuel prices are politically sensitive for the White House. I could not verify this week's Fed or jobs figures, so I leave them out. Check the Fed's next meeting, due in December, and the October inflation report, due in mid-November.

Foreign policy: Russia, China and Congress

Washington is pushing Russia–Ukraine talks in Abu Dhabi (see Russia & Ukraine). It is also pressing Beijing to honour the Busan trade deal (see China). The FT reports that European officials fear a US–Russia security deal that would undermine NATO and restore a Russian sphere of influence. Bloomberg says a Democratic Congress could constrain Trump through spending decisions, Ukraine aid, Russia sanctions and oversight.

For Europe & Italy: Europe faces a divided Washington. A Democratic Congress is more favourable on Ukraine aid and sanctions. A Trump–Miller White House remains unpredictable on tariffs and on any deal with Moscow. Italian exporters, who sell heavily to the US, remain exposed to tariff shifts.

Watch: Trump's trip to Shenzhen for the APEC summit (Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation) in about two weeks, and Miller's first executive actions.

Sources: Bloomberg, Bloomberg, ANSA, NBC News, BBC, FT, FT, FT, Bloomberg

China

Beijing's week was dominated by trade friction with Washington ahead of two planned Trump–Xi meetings. Domestically, it defended its stock market and prepared for the 2027 party congress.

Washington tells Beijing to deliver on the Busan deal

On 6 November the US warned China it must "immediately" meet the terms of the Busan trade deal, the FT reported. Washington says Beijing is not delivering on its pledges to supply more rare earths and other critical products, and on agriculture purchases (Japan Times). Trump and Xi are expected to meet twice: at the APEC summit in Shenzhen in about two weeks, and later in the US. The FT also reported that Washington, Moscow and Beijing have discussed a possible Trump–Putin–Xi meeting.

Why it matters: The Busan truce was struck by Trump and Xi on 30 October 2025. China paused some rare earth export controls for a year and promised more US farm purchases. Rare earths are essential for magnets in cars, wind turbines and weapons, so Beijing's licensing gives it leverage.

Market impact: Chinese equities are getting a lift as investors rotate out of AI (Bloomberg). Beijing is also propping up the market: ETFs commonly used for state support took their second-highest net inflows on record (FT).

Watch: China's October trade data on 10 November. September exports rose about 36% year on year, per CNBC and Fortune. A very large surplus fuels pressure from Europe to rebalance trade.

Tech and investment: tightening on both sides

Nvidia told cloud clients that most of their customers must be non-Chinese, the FT reported (3 November). China's foreign-investment security review halted a $5.4 billion SoftBank–ABB robotics deal, and the companies are weighing a China carve-out (Japan Times). On Friday the FT reported that US intelligence believes Nvidia chief Jensen Huang had a romantic relationship with an executive allegedly recruited by China. This is a US-sourced claim, and I have not seen a response.

For Europe & Italy: ABB is Swiss, and the case shows how Beijing can block foreign industrial deals. Italian and EU firms in robotics and machinery face similar risks. France is also urging an EU levy on fast fashion, which targets Chinese platforms (FT).

Politics, Taiwan and economy

Xinhua said the 21st Party Congress in 2027 will have 2,360 delegates, 60 more than the last (Bloomberg). That points to Xi continuing his leadership past that congress. The Economist notes that Beijing and Taipei are contesting the legacy of Sun Yat-sen ahead of his 160th birthday on 12 November. CCTV says China will invest $940 billion in energy in 2026. Japan Times reports that an Astellas employee jailed for espionage will be released in December.

Watch: The Xi–Trump meetings, the 10 November trade data, and any Chinese moves around 12 November.

Sources: FT, Japan Times, FT, FT, FT, Japan Times, FT, Bloomberg, Economist, CNBC, Bloomberg

Russia & Ukraine

Diplomacy picked up while Russia kept hitting Ukraine's power grid. I could not verify this week's front-line changes, so I make no territorial claims.

Abu Dhabi talks on 10–11 November

The US, Russia and Ukraine meet in Abu Dhabi on 10–11 November. These are the first three-way talks since February, per the FT. Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner lead the US side, and Witkoff says the agenda covers security arrangements, de-escalation and humanitarian issues. Bloomberg reports Russia is sending a higher-level team than before, which could signal more substance after months of deadlock. Before that, US, UK, EU and NATO officials were to meet in Brussels. On 5 November Melania Trump hosted Russian and Ukrainian officials at the White House to mark the Oleshky truce, a short local ceasefire in the Russian-held Kherson-region town. Kirill Dmitriev, Putin's envoy, attended. Trump said he met Dmitriev privately and predicted a deal. Sources differ on how long the truce lasted.

Why it matters: The main obstacle remains Donbas, which Putin wants in full, according to CBS and others. Trump's optimism has outrun results before.

For Europe & Italy: The FT reports that European officials fear a US–Russia security deal over their heads. A Franco-British-led exercise in Poland, with 2,800 troops from 11 nations, rehearses a postwar force for Ukraine (Defense News). Politico reports NATO faces a €7 billion shortfall on its military-aid pledge to Ukraine.

Watch: Whether Moscow shows flexibility on Donbas, and whether security guarantees are discussed with Europeans.

Strikes on the grid

Russian strikes on 7 November wounded nine people and damaged the power network (BBC). By Sunday about 600,000 people in eastern Ukraine's Dnipropetrovsk region were without power (Politico). Russia's defence ministry claimed a "massive strike" on energy and Odesa-region port facilities. Zelensky called for more sanctions before the talks.

Hybrid pressure on Europe

Security agencies are probing whether a wave of flight and newsroom bomb hoaxes started in Russia; the working hypothesis is pro-Kremlin activists or hackers (FT). Meloni blamed pro-Russian hackers for a cyberattack on her foreign minister (Bloomberg). A cyberattack on the UK meat industry raised temperatures in supermarket freezers in Ireland, Sweden and Belgium, and the BBC gave no attribution.

> **Background — space and communications:** Ukrainian intelligence says Russia already uses its Rassvet satellite network, a Starlink rival, for military communications. Kyiv itself is uncertain about its Starshield contract with SpaceX after problems in October.

Sources: FT, Bloomberg, CBS News, NBC News, FT, Defense News, Politico Europe, BBC, Politico Europe, FT, Bloomberg, BBC, Defense News, Breaking Defense

III World Regions

Middle East & Gulf

The week's main stories were a widening Saudi-Houthi war, a stalled US-Iran standoff that moved oil prices sharply, and a major shift in US military aid to Israel. I found no verified reporting this week on Gaza, the West Bank, Lebanon, Syria, Iraq or Turkey, so I do not cover them.

Houthis hit Aramco's Riyadh tower as Saudi strikes escalate

The Iran-backed Houthis of Yemen hit the 34-storey Aramco Tower in Riyadh's business district. Saudi Arabia's energy ministry said falling debris caused "limited damage" and no deaths or injuries (Handelsblatt/ dpa, 8 Nov). The Houthi health ministry says a Saudi air strike on Sanaa killed at least 33 people, including 13 children. Riyadh has not commented on that claim (BBC).

Why it matters: The 2022 truce collapsed this year and fighting resumed in July. The Yemen Data Project counted more than 430 Saudi-led bombings in October, which Handelsblatt calls the heaviest since 2017. Near-daily Houthi attacks are damaging the kingdom's image as a safe place for business and tourism.

Watch: Whether Saudi air defences keep holding over Riyadh, and any US or Gulf mediation.

Sources: Handelsblatt, BBC

Iran standoff: blockade, mines and a 16% weekly oil drop

Neither side has moved. War on the Rocks (6 Nov) describes an impasse after the US midterms, with Washington holding a naval blockade and sanctions. Tehran calls a "no-war, no-peace" status quo unacceptable and wants guarantees against attack during talks. The FT reported on 5 Nov that Russia deepened military support for Iran with a missile-launcher deal.

Market impact: Market-news sites report Brent fell about 16% in the week to settle near $98.32 on Friday, from about $117.64 the week before. Traders were betting on a deal even though none exists. The IRGC (Iran's Revolutionary Guards) claimed two more tankers hit mines in Hormuz on 6 Nov. No independent authority has confirmed that. Eurasia Group reportedly puts the odds of a deal at 10%.

For Europe & Italy: Italy imports much of its energy, so a swing of this size affects fuel and gas prices.

Watch: OPEC's monthly report on 11 Nov and the OPEC+ ministerial meeting on 29 Nov.

Sources: War on the Rocks, FT, Gulf News

Trump says US military aid to Israel ends

On 3 Nov Trump said the US will stop the roughly $4bn in annual military aid to Israel from 2027 and sell it weapons instead. He said Netanyahu had asked for this. The Prime Minister's Office backed the move as a shift "from aid to partnership". Aid currently runs at $3.8bn a year under a 10-year agreement. In January Netanyahu spoke of tapering aid over 10 years.

Why it matters: The aid featured in the midterm campaign. The FT (7 Nov) argues Trump's midterm defeat points to a wider US retreat that could open space for China in the region.

Watch: How the cut is phased in, and whether Congress, which funds the aid, objects.

Sources: FT, AP via KSAT, FT

Gulf energy deals

Shell will sell an Australian gas stake to Abu Dhabi's XRG for $1.45bn (FT, 3 Nov). Qatar is set to become the biggest buyer of US LNG, with the largest share of US output by 2033 (FT, 4 Nov).

Sources: FT, FT

Indo-Pacific

The week was dominated by a sharp sell-off in Asian tech stocks and by US-China manoeuvring before two planned leader meetings. Nothing I could verify this week covers North Korea, South Korea or the India-Pakistan front.

Tokyo's biggest one-day fall since April 2025

The Nikkei 225 and Topix fell nearly 6% on 6 Nov, their biggest one-day drop since the "liberation day" tariff turmoil of April 2025 (FT). Global stocks fell the same day on fears of tougher scrutiny of data-centre construction and the AI industry (BBC). Bloomberg (8 Nov) says the AI unwind is reviving "forgotten" Asian trades, namely Chinese and Indian stocks and companies that would gain from easing inflation.

Market impact: Money is rotating out of AI-linked tech and towards cheaper Asian markets. Toyota rose 17% on 5 Nov after raising its outlook on strong US hybrid demand.

Watch: Whether the AI sell-off spreads to chipmakers in Taiwan and South Korea.

Sources: FT, BBC, Bloomberg

US presses China on rare earths before Trump-Xi meetings

Washington urged Beijing on 7 Nov to meet its rare-earth and farm-purchase commitments before two meetings between Trump and Xi (Japan Times). Reports from earlier sources say the sides extended their trade truce to 10 Jan 2027. They also say the leaders plan to meet at APEC in Shenzhen this month and at the G20 in Miami in December. I could not check those dates against a Tier-1 outlet.

Beijing also halted the $5.4bn SoftBank-ABB robotics deal through a foreign-investment security review. The companies are weighing a China carve-out (Japan Times). A Chinese spy-agency asset reportedly targeted Nvidia's Jensen Huang.

Watch: Beijing's rare-earth export licences and the 10 Jan truce deadline.

Sources: Japan Times, Japan Times, Japan Times

Japan hedges against China and Russia

Japan picked 28 priority items, including chips and AI, from 62 candidates for ¥370 trillion in investment. Japanese firms signed about $21bn of LNG deals (FT). Putin ordered the seizure of Japan Tobacco's Russian business. China will release a jailed Astellas employee in December. The China-Japan row is a year old, and both countries are shifting to "selective" economic dependence.

Taiwan, Southeast Asia and Australia

China and Taiwan are contesting the legacy of Sun Yat-sen ahead of his 160th birthday (Economist). In Indonesia and Malaysia, residents are protesting over water and power use by data centres. Apple books profits in Singapore, saving $2.7bn in tax. David Jones, Australia's oldest department store, entered receivership after 188 years.

Sources: Japan Times, FT, Economist, BBC

BRICS+ & Global South

This was a quiet week for BRICS as a bloc. Its last big moment was the New Delhi summit in September under India's chair year. Reports say the summit's declaration was adopted unanimously, urged "restraint" in the Middle East, and for the first time named India, Brazil and South Africa as candidates for permanent UN Security Council seats.

China's clean-tech push into the developing world

China sent $132bn in clean technology and investment to developing countries last year, the largest contribution of any country (Japan Times, 8 Nov). The EU's climate agency said the world is "virtually certain" to exceed 1.5C of warming in 2026, with October the warmest on record at 1.75C above pre-industrial levels (FT).

Why it matters: Beijing is becoming the main supplier of the energy transition in the Global South, while the US retreats.

For Europe & Italy: The EU's competitors for Global South influence are offering cheaper, faster hardware. Argentina is pitching Brussels on food, energy and minerals "solutions" (FT, 3 Nov).

Sources: Japan Times, FT, FT

Payments fragmentation

Denis Beau, first deputy governor of the Bank of France, spoke at the South African Reserve Bank payments conference in Pretoria on 21 Oct. His topic was "payments in a fragmenting world", meaning sovereignty and system design (BIS, published 3 Nov). The pressure behind it is real. US sanctions could cut the ICC off from dollar settlements as early as April, which shows how dollar-based systems can be used as leverage (Japan Times).

Watch: The US-led G20 in Miami in December, where BRICS members will test Washington's agenda.

Sources: BIS, Japan Times

Africa

The most significant event was institutional. The week also brought a further round of pressure on Rwanda. I could not verify this week's battlefield developments in Sudan, eastern Congo or the Sahel.

UN peacekeeping in Western Sahara ends after 35 years

A US-Russia impasse at the UN Security Council left the mission, MINURSO, without a mandate, so it has ended after 35 years (BBC, 3 Nov). Morocco World News, a Moroccan outlet, reports the US vetoed a Russian draft that would have extended the mandate unchanged. It says 11 members voted against the Russian text. I could not confirm the vote count independently. The BBC says Morocco is celebrating. Western Sahara is largely controlled by Morocco and claimed by the Algeria-backed Polisario Front (Japan Times).

Why it matters: MINURSO was created in 1991 to monitor a ceasefire and organise a referendum that never happened. Its end removes the UN's last presence there and favours Rabat's claim.

For Europe & Italy: Morocco and Algeria are important partners for Europe on migration and gas.

Watch: Polisario's reaction and Algeria's response.

Sources: BBC, Japan Times, Morocco World News

Rwanda under US sanctions over Congo

Around 28-29 Oct the US sanctioned Rwanda's defence ministry and the Zigama Credit and Savings Society over support for the M23 rebels in eastern Congo (AP via Africanews). The US had already sanctioned the Rwandan army in March. On 4 Nov the NBA said Rwanda's army team was removed from the Basketball Africa League. Rwanda denies backing M23, but UN experts say it does. AP says diplomacy has had little effect on the ground.

Watch: Whether sanctions change the talks on Congo's minerals.

Sources: BBC, Africanews

Italy's Africa angle

Paolo Angelini, senior deputy governor of the Bank of Italy, spoke on Africa's home-grown development in Palermo on 26 Oct (BIS, 3 Nov).

Source: BIS

Latin America

Politics, not markets, drove the week: Paraguay's president was removed, Haiti's security effort brought in outside forces, and US midterm results changed the picture in Washington.

Paraguay removes President Peña over bank collapse

Santiago Peña announced his resignation on 5 Nov. Congress refused to accept it and pressed ahead with impeachment. The lower house voted 78-0 to impeach him. The Senate removed him on 6 Nov (AP, Bloomberg). Removal by impeachment bars him from the lifetime Senate seat a resignation would have brought. Bloomberg reports he has been criminally charged over the collapse of Ueno Bank. Vice President Pedro Alliana takes over and would serve until August 2028. Prosecutors have opened three criminal probes. Nearly 3 million Ueno customers still cannot withdraw cash or use their cards. Protests have clashed with police using rubber bullets.

Why it matters: The crisis ends the presidency of one of the region's most US-aligned conservative leaders.

Watch: Alliana's first moves and whether depositors get their money back.

Sources: AP via NPR/WLRN, Bloomberg

Haiti brings in Salvadoran troops and mercenaries

Haitian officials say they killed a major gang leader in Port-au-Prince. At least 2,000 Salvadoran troops and private mercenaries are joining the fight to retake the capital (Bloomberg, 7 Nov).

Watch: Human-rights scrutiny of the mercenaries and the new Salvadoran deployment.

Source: Bloomberg

US politics and the region

A Democratic wave in the US midterms strengthens opponents of Trump's regional policy. The FT notes that California's "Proposition 40" billionaire tax is set to be defeated even so. Argentina is courting the EU (see the BRICS+ section).

Sources: FT

IV Security, Technology & Space

Defence & Security

Diplomacy and war ran side by side this week. The first US, Russian and Ukrainian talks since February are due in Abu Dhabi on 10–11 November, and Europe is worried about what Washington might agree with Moscow. No general ceasefire is in place.

Europe scrambles to align before Abu Dhabi talks

On 3 November the FT reported that the US would hold its first talks with Russia and Ukraine since February. On 4 November the European Commission hosted officials from Ukraine, the US, NATO, Germany, France, the UK and the World Bank in Brussels. No concrete agreements were reported, according to the Kyiv Independent. An October round collapsed when the Kremlin declined to attend, and Moscow keeps rejecting an unconditional ceasefire while demanding that Ukraine cede Donbas. On 5 November the White House hosted Kirill Dmitriev, Putin's envoy, and Ukraine's David Arakhamia. The event marked a local, temporary ceasefire around Oleshky, a town in occupied southern Ukraine, which let aid in and civilians out. The White House credited Melania Trump, but that credit comes largely from the White House itself.

Why it matters: On 6 November the FT reported that European officials fear a US-Russia security deal that would undermine NATO and restore a Russian sphere of influence.

For Europe & Italy: Rome and other capitals are being asked to plan for a postwar order they may not control. Britain and France will lead 2,800 troops from 11 nations in a two-week exercise in Poland. It tests how to move, protect and supply a force to rebuild Ukraine's military after the war (Defense News). Politico also reports that NATO faces a €7 billion shortfall on its military-aid pledge to Ukraine. I could not verify the details.

Watch: The Abu Dhabi round on 10–11 November, and whether Moscow actually attends.

Sources: FT, Kyiv Independent, FT, Defense News, Politico Europe

Russia builds its own space network, and deepens ties with Iran

Ukrainian military intelligence says Russia already uses its new Rassvet satellite network, billed as a homegrown Starlink, for military communications over Ukraine. The FT says it would allow more deadly drone strikes deep inside Ukraine. The FT also reported on 5 November that Moscow supplied Iran with a missile-launcher deal despite strains from the Ukraine war.

Watch: Whether Russia's constellation grows beyond Ukrainian claims, and any Western response on Iran.

Sources: Defense News, FT

Budgets and industry

After the US midterms, Defense One reports that a reconciliation bill for defence money is likely off the table. The presumed House Armed Services chair is talking about a $1 trillion cap. In Europe, the Commission is expected by the end of November to pick one of two consortia to develop a hypersonic-missile interceptor, with a demonstrator targeted for 2030 (Breaking Defense). Polish drone maker WB Electronics is moving towards a Warsaw IPO next year that could be worth around €7 billion (FT). Germany is building Panzerbrigade 45 in Lithuania, with nearly 5,000 soldiers due by 2027 (Politico).

Market impact: European defence listings and any US spending cap are the pricing signals to follow.

Sources: Defense One, Breaking Defense, FT, Politico Europe

Cyber & Information Warfare

Pro-Russian hacking and hybrid pressure on Italy and Europe dominated the week.

Italy: foreign minister's data leaked, security committee called

On 7 November Prime Minister Giorgia Meloni blamed pro-Russian hackers for a cyberattack on Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani. Tajani said hackers had leaked his personal data online (BBC, Bloomberg). On 8 November Interior Minister Matteo Piantedosi convened the national public-order and security committee for Tuesday at the Interior Ministry (ANSA). Open reported in October that the Foreign Ministry's website was hit after sharp Moscow statements against Tajani.

Why it matters: Pro-Russian groups such as NoName057(16) have repeatedly targeted Italy since 2023. Leaks of personal data are harder to dismiss than denial-of-service attacks on websites.

Watch: Tuesday's committee outcome, and any formal attribution by Italy's National Cybersecurity Agency (ACN).

Sources: Bloomberg, BBC, ANSA, Open

Supermarket freezers and bomb hoaxes

On Monday 3 November supermarkets in Ireland, Sweden and Belgium reported fridge temperatures being raised, and the BBC linked the wave to a cyberattack on the UK meat industry. Press reports say the attackers changed setpoints on refrigeration management systems. Reported temperatures vary widely by source, so they are unreliable. The UK's NCSC reportedly confirmed that vulnerable refrigeration technology was exploited in a small number of incidents. On 7 November the FT reported that European agencies are examining whether coordinated bomb hoaxes began in Russia. The working hypothesis is pro-Kremlin activists or hacking groups. This is unproven.

Other incidents

US prosecutors are working to extradite three suspects from Europe over AI-assisted CEO-impersonation fraud worth more than $100 million. FBI agent Patrick Yaroch pleaded guilty to stealing $2.4 million in crypto seized from hackers. Industry groups want the US cyber threat-sharing law extended through 2035. War on the Rocks describes a spring 2026 exercise off Norway in which Russian submersibles simulated attacks on the Svalbard undersea cables.

Sources: BBC, FT, The Record, The Record, Defense One, War on the Rocks

Fact Check

I found no formal debunk from the main fact-checkers on this week's headline stories. The three items below test widely repeated framings against the reporting, and they are not verdicts issued by those outlets.

The claim: "Melania Trump secured a ceasefire between Russia and Ukraine"

The line spread through White House statements and US media coverage around the 5 November event.

Verdict: Missing context

What is actually true: The truce was local, covering Oleshky, and temporary. It was reported to have begun on 29 October and to have expired days later, after nearly 800 people reportedly left. No general ceasefire exists. Moscow still rejects an unconditional one (Kyiv Independent). Her role comes mainly from the White House and her own remarks. A Ukrainian figure said the issue was handled by the human-rights commissioner, Dmytro Lubinets.

Why it matters: The framing suggests a peace breakthrough that has not happened, just before the Abu Dhabi talks.

Sources: BBC, Kyiv Independent

The claim: "Nvidia's Jensen Huang was caught working with a Chinese spy"

The claim spread on social media after the reports of 5–7 November.

Verdict: Unproven

What is actually true: The FT reports that US intelligence believes Huang had a relationship with Alice Huang, a Megaspeed executive who is alleged to be a Chinese intelligence asset. Japan Times links her to China's Ministry of State Security. Nvidia calls the contacts routine business, and China's foreign ministry dismissed the reports. According

to reporting, the New York Times did not establish that Huang knew of any espionage, and nobody has been charged. House Republicans have asked for a closed-door briefing on 18 November.

Why it matters: It feeds the US debate over chip sales to China.

Sources: FT, Japan Times, FT

The claim: "The US election crashed AI stocks"

This line ran in market commentary.

Verdict: Misleading

What is actually true: The selloff followed investor fears that Democratic gains could mean tighter data-centre rules (BBC). The BBC also notes that worries about the industry have been growing for some time. Some analysts see a leverage unwind. At the time of reporting, no chamber of Congress had been formally called.

Why it matters: A single-cause story hides the underlying valuation worries.

Sources: BBC

Technology & AI

This was the week the AI trade cracked. China tightened its grip on tech deals, and Washington turned its scrutiny on Nvidia.

AI stocks plunge after the US midterms

The Nasdaq Composite fell 5.5% on Thursday 5 November, its worst day since the April 2025 tariff rout. The Nasdaq 100 lost 6.3%, roughly $2.5 trillion, and the Philadelphia chip index fell 12.2%. Nvidia dropped 9.3%. On Friday the Nikkei 225 closed down 5.96% at 57,435, its worst week since 2020, and Topix fell 5.9% (market reports via search aggregators; FT, BBC). Korea's Kospi triggered a circuit breaker.

Why it matters: Investors feared Democratic gains in the midterms could mean tougher scrutiny of data-centre construction and AI. The BBC also notes concerns about the industry had been building.

For Europe & Italy: Europe's markets pulled back too. Bloomberg reports the rout is reviving out-of-favour Chinese and Indian stocks.

Market impact: Chipmakers and AI-linked indices fell hardest. Some analysts call it a leverage unwind rather than a lasting repricing, which is an analyst view and not a fact.

Watch: Whether the selloff extends into Monday, and the first AI-related signals from the new Congress.

Sources: BBC, FT, Bloomberg

Nvidia: China exposure and congressional pressure

On 3 November the FT reported that Nvidia ordered its cloud customers to ensure most of their clients are non-Chinese, reducing China exposure. On 5–6 November three House Republican committee chairs asked Huang for a closed-door briefing on 18 November about his reported relationship with Alice Huang, who is alleged to be a Chinese intelligence asset. Nvidia calls the contacts routine, and she has not been charged.

Sources: FT, FT

China blocks SoftBank-ABB robotics deal

China's foreign-investment security review office has halted a $5.4 billion SoftBank-ABB robotics deal. The companies are considering a China carve-out to save it (Japan Times). Beijing is also supporting its own stock market, with record-level inflows into state-favoured ETFs (FT).

Sources: Japan Times, FT

EU charges TikTok under the Digital Services Act

On 6 November the Commission accused TikTok of failing to stop its recommendation algorithm from pulling users into harmful "rabbit holes" about sadness, self-harm and body image. This is a preliminary finding under the Digital Services Act (DSA), the EU's platform-safety law. Fines can reach 6% of global turnover, but a final decision comes later.

Watch: TikTok's reply and any commitments.

Sources: The Record

Energy and capital

Anthropic struck a $3.4 billion deal to generate gas-fired power for its data centres, bypassing traditional suppliers to secure scarce equipment (FT). Wall Street firm XN holds a $5.3 billion stake in Anthropic and plans to double down despite the rout (FT). In Indonesia and Malaysia, residents are protesting data centres they say disrupt local water and power (Japan Times). Japan named 28 priority items, including chips and AI, for ¥370 trillion in investment. Apple saved $2.7 billion in taxes by booking profits in Singapore (FT).

Sources: FT, FT, Japan Times, Japan Times, FT

Space

Military space was the theme of the week: both Russia's Starlink rival and the Pentagon's Golden Dome plans moved forward.

NASA widens Moon Base awards

On Saturday 7 November NASA announced awards for commercial robotic lunar deliveries, launch and orbital-transfer services, surface infrastructure and science. They include a nuclear-powered rover called PROMISE. NASA frames the work as building a sustained human presence on the Moon with US industry.

Watch: Which companies win the delivery slots and the first launch dates.

Sources: NASA

Golden Dome data network takes shape

On 6 November the Pentagon gave Viasat an indefinite-delivery contract worth up to $450 million for the mission operations centre of the Space Data Network Backbone. That is the satellite data-relay layer of the Golden Dome missile-defence plan. Breaking Defense separately reports, citing sources, that key Space Force satellites cannot talk to each other. Fixing that could need a roughly $1 billion fix of 12 or 13 "Space Exchange Point" satellites. The Backbone is built by SpaceX.

Market impact: Viasat gains a defence revenue stream. The cost question for Golden Dome grows.

Sources: Breaking Defense, Breaking Defense

Starshield, Rassvet and rivals

Ukraine hopes to sign a new SpaceX Starshield deal by mid-2027. Its chargé d'affaires Denys Sienik said Kyiv is also weighing alternatives, and Ukraine still has no answers about October problems (Breaking Defense). Russia, meanwhile, is racing to build Rassvet, which Kyiv says already carries military traffic. In Canada, Wall Street opposition threatens Telesat's rival constellation plan, which would also need SpaceX rockets (FT). In China, LandSpace has emerged as a national champion under a "swarm" strategy (FT).

Funding and launch capacity

CesiumAstro raised $730 million in a Series D at a valuation above $4.5 billion. SpaceNews notes that operators still lack enough rides to orbit despite record launches.

Sources: Breaking Defense, FT, FT, SpaceNews, SpaceNews

V Economy, Markets & Energy

Global Economy & Central Banks

Energy-driven inflation dominated the week, and three central banks are now leaning towards tighter policy. The Bank of England (BoE) raised rates. The European Central Bank (ECB) and the Federal Reserve held earlier, and both have left the door open to more hikes. Markets are also pricing a possible US–Iran deal, which makes the inflation path hard to read.

Eurozone inflation hits 4.0% as the ECB heads for a leadership change

Eurostat's flash estimate on 4 November put euro-area inflation at 4.0% in October, up from 3.8% in September and the highest since September 2023. Energy inflation rose to 20.8%, while core inflation (which strips out energy, food, alcohol and tobacco) held at 2.5%. Italy rose to 5.6%, France to 3.8% and Spain eased to 4.9%. Germany fell to 2.8%, partly because of a temporary fuel-tax cut.

The ECB held its deposit rate at 2.50% on 29 October, after hikes in June and September. On 7 November Lagarde told the Yomiuri Shimbun that inflation will likely stay high in the near term and that second-round effects (energy costs feeding into wages and other prices) are no worse than expected. Bank of Finland board member Tuomas Välimäki said the path back to 2% "has become less comfortable".

Why it matters: Lagarde is due to leave on 7 February 2027, earlier than her term required. Nominations closed on Friday with two candidates: Klaas Knot (Netherlands) and Pablo Hernández de Cos (Spain), per Politico Europe and the Japan Times. A late surprise entrant is still possible.

For Europe & Italy: Italy's 5.6% is well above the euro-area average, which hits household budgets and Italian business costs. Confcommercio, the retailers' and services lobby, called energy bills "ever heavier" for firms.

Watch: Final October inflation data on 18 November. The ECB meets next on 17 December, and some analysts expect one more hike to 2.75%.

Sources: Eurostat flash via StockAnalysis, ECB, Bloomberg, Politico Europe, Japan Times, BIS

Bank of England hikes to 4.00%

On 5 November the Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) raised Bank Rate by 0.25 points to 4.00%, by 8–1. It was the first hike since August 2023. Catherine Mann dissented in favour of 0.5 points. Swati Dhingra and Alan Taylor switched from holding to hiking. The Bank cited energy prices lifting the inflation outlook; UK inflation is reported at 3.5%. The next meeting is 17 December.

Sources: Bank of England

US: strong jobs, Fed on hold with a hawkish tilt

The Fed held at 3.75%–4.00% on 28 October by 10–2, with both dissenters favouring a hike. It had raised rates in September. Payrolls then rose by 165,000 in October, far above consensus estimates of roughly 62,000–65,000. Unemployment fell to 4.1%, and wages rose 3.1% on the year, below inflation. The US 10-year yield closed the week at 4.86%.

Sources: Federal Reserve, BLS

Japan

BoJ Governor Kazuo Ueda said it is unclear how long inflation will stay at 2%, and that the public has not yet absorbed the idea that the goal was reached. USD/JPY closed at 158.43.

Sources: Japan Times

I found no major IMF or OECD outlook release or People's Bank of China (PBoC) move this week.

Markets & Finance

An AI-led selloff after the US midterms hit stocks on Wednesday and Thursday, and Asia was hit hardest on Friday. Oil's 16% weekly drop, driven by hopes of a US–Iran deal, was the other big move. Everything below is price action; the explanations are reporters' and analysts' readings, not facts.

Tech rout, then a partial rebound

The Nasdaq 100 fell 4.91% over the week and the S&P 500 2.68%. The VIX, the gauge of expected US stock volatility, rose 32% to 25.64. Reports said the Nasdaq entered correction territory (a fall of 10% or more) and that about $2.5 trillion was erased from the Nasdaq 100. Reporting tied the selloff to Democrats' takeover of Congress, which raises the prospect of tougher oversight of AI and data-centre building. Local data-centre ballot measures also largely went against the industry. The Nasdaq 100 rebounded 1.35% on Friday.

Asia took the sharpest hit on Friday. The Nikkei fell 5.96% (11.17% on the week), the KOSPI 6.02% (11.71%) and the Taiex 4.51%. Memory-chip makers led: SK Hynix lost more than 8% and Samsung about 7% in early trading. Europe fell 0.6%–1.9% on Friday but ended the week mostly higher: IBEX +3.84%, CAC 40 +2.13%, FTSE MIB +1.12% to 50,053, DAX flat.

Market expectations (not fact): Bloomberg says the AI unwind is reviving "forgotten" Asian trades. Nifty 50 gained 6.59% and the Hang Seng 5.10%. The FT reports record-scale ETF inflows as Beijing props up Chinese stocks.

Sources: BBC, SCMP, FT, Bloomberg

Oil, gold and the dollar

Brent fell 16.42% on the week to $98.32 and WTI fell 12.76% to $90.83. Traders are betting on a US–Iran settlement, although none has been signed. Gold rose 4.51% to $4,074.90 and silver 5.79%. The dollar index rose to 102.30 and EUR/USD ended near 1.12. Bitcoin slipped 1.91% to about $75,871. Bloomberg says crypto's political tailwind in Washington is ending as Democrats take Congress.

Credit and deals

- **Berkshire Hathaway:** Spent a record $9.6 billion on buybacks in the third quarter while operating earnings slipped.
- **Meta:** Sold $25 billion of bonds on Election Day.
- **Arini:** The FT says the London fund's junk-bond bets are souring.
- **WB Electronics:** The Polish drone maker is preparing a roughly €7 billion Warsaw IPO.
- **Shell and Abu Dhabi's XRG:** Shell agreed to sell an Australian gas stake to XRG for $1.45 billion.

Watch: US inflation data and any US–Iran news next week.

Sources: Bloomberg, Bloomberg, FT, FT, FT

Trade, Tariffs & Sanctions

The US–China relationship was the central trade story, with Washington pressing Beijing to deliver on last year's truce before leader-level meetings. Sanctions news came from Russia and the International Criminal Court (ICC).

US tells China to meet Busan terms "immediately"

On Friday 6 November, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer spoke with Chinese Vice Premier He Lifeng. Bessent's readout said Beijing must fully and immediately honour its commitments and that he "raised concerns about recent Chinese actions". Washington says China is not supplying rare earths and other critical products at the agreed pace, and that farm purchases lag. Greer focused on agriculture and critical minerals. President Trump and Xi Jinping are expected to meet at two summits, one in China and one in the US. Shenzhen is preparing to host the Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation (APEC) gathering.

Why it matters: Under the October 2025 Busan truce, China agreed to buy 25 million tonnes of US soybeans over three years and to ease rare-earth curbs. The truce was later extended to 10 January 2027, according to coverage of the call. Bloomberg Economics notes that Trump keeps

broad unilateral authority over tariffs even with Democrats controlling Congress. Congress's leverage lies mainly in spending, oversight, Ukraine aid and Russia sanctions.

For Europe & Italy: Rare-earth magnets feed European carmakers and machinery makers, including Italian suppliers. A breakdown in the truce would tighten supply and raise costs.

Watch: Summit dates, new rare-earth licence data and any January truce-extension talks.

> **Background — Busan truce:** In late October 2025 Trump and Xi agreed in South Korea to pause an escalation of tariffs and Chinese export controls on rare earths. Both sides have since accused each other of slow delivery.

Sources: FT, Japan Times, Bloomberg

China blocks SoftBank–ABB robotics deal

China's foreign-investment security review office halted the $5.4 billion deal. SoftBank and ABB are now considering carving out the China business to rescue it.

Sources: Japan Times

Russia: diesel gambit falters, pressure for more sanctions

The FT reports that Trump's diesel arrangement with Russia is faltering. US fuel stocks are at a 20-year low and two tankers changed course. Russia is rerouting pig iron exports via Murmansk for the first time in 30 years to avoid Ukrainian strikes. Zelenskyy called for further sanctions on Russia ahead of talks in Abu Dhabi.

Sources: FT, FT, Politico Europe

ICC under US sanctions

Japan is considering an early funding contribution to the ICC. Full US sanctions could cut the court off from dollar settlements as early as April.

Sources: Japan Times

Italy: steel

Metinvest withdrew from the €3.2 billion Piombino steel project, adding to the troubles at Taranto.

Sources: Il Sole 24 Ore

Energy & Critical Minerals

Oil fell sharply on peace hopes, but gas and fuel markets remain tight. The Iran war has disrupted Gulf flows for months, and Europe is heading into winter with storage below normal.

Oil: biggest weekly drop in years, but no deal

Brent fell about 16% to $98.32 and WTI to $90.83. Reports tie the move to expectations of a US–Iran settlement after the midterms. No agreement has been signed. The Revolutionary Guards reported more tanker attacks in the Strait of Hormuz on Thursday, and Iran is demanding that the US naval blockade be lifted, sanctions relief and the release of frozen assets. The Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries and allies (OPEC+) left December output unchanged on 1 November, for the third time in a row. Its next ministerial meeting is 29 November.

Why it matters: The price now embeds a diplomatic outcome. A failed deal or fresh shipping attacks could reverse it quickly. Separately, FT reports US fuel inventories are at a 20-year low.

For Europe & Italy: Lower crude eases pressure on petrol and diesel, but Italy's headline inflation of 5.6% shows how far energy costs still feed through.

Watch: Hormuz incidents, US–Iran talks and the 29 November OPEC+ meeting.

Gas: Europe still exposed

Dutch TTF gas closed near €85.59/MWh. Late October saw about €95.7, the highest since 2022, and EU storage was only 74.6% full on 25 October against a five-year average near 86%. Qatar's LNG shipments, normally the world's second-largest, have been reduced to a trickle since the war began. A report said QatarEnergy extended force majeure to

year-end, which I could not confirm independently. Japanese firms struck $21 billion of deals to secure gas, including US Gulf Coast shale, which sets up competition with Europe for LNG.

Sources: FT, Oilprice

Power, data centres and grids

Anthropic signed a $3.4 billion deal to generate gas-fired power for data centres, bypassing traditional suppliers to secure scarce equipment. EU capitals urged Brussels to sign an electricity-market deal with the UK swiftly.

Sources: FT, Politico Europe

Metals and critical minerals

Copper fell 3.42% on the week to $6.24/lb, while silver rose 5.79%. US officials complain rare earths from China are arriving below agreed volumes (see Trade).

Climate and clean energy

The EU's Copernicus service said October was the warmest on record, 1.75C above pre-industrial levels, and that 2026 is "virtually certain" to exceed 1.5C. The Turkish presidency of the COP31 climate summit in Antalya will ask governments to commit to electrification, citing a global electricity share of just over 20% of final energy use; Il Sole 24 Ore says Italy lags. China's state broadcaster CCTV said China will invest $940 billion in energy in 2026, the most of any country. The Japan Times says China sent $132 billion in clean tech and investment to developing countries last year.

Sources: FT, Il Sole 24 Ore, Bloomberg, Japan Times

VI Analysis & Outlook

How Others See It

Abu Dhabi talks and a possible US-Russia security deal

View point	How they frame it	Key words
West (US)	Witkoff says the agenda covers security arrangements, de-escalation and humanitarian issues. Trump predicts a deal "soon".	"Deal", "de-escalation"
Europe	FT and Politico report capitals fear a plan linked to Jared Kushner that could undermine NATO. Europe wants a say in guarantees.	"Sphere of influence", "over our heads"
Russia	Moscow rejects an unconditional ceasefire and demands Donbas, per reporting. Kirill Dmitriev attended the White House event.	Donbas, "not possible" (gas transit)
Ukraine	Zelensky wants more sanctions before talks. Kyiv sees the Oleshky truce as limited.	Sanctions, guarantees
Gulf	The UAE hosts, and Qatar, Saudi Arabia and Turkey mediate elsewhere.	Venue, mediation

Agreed: The talks open on 10-11 November. **Disputed:** how long the Oleshky truce lasted, who deserves credit for it, and whether Russia is serious.

The Iran standoff and oil

Viewpoint	How they frame it	Key words
US	Naval blockade and sanctions stay. Reports describe talks via Qatar.	Blockade, "deal soon"
Iran	Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei says anyone expecting US policy to change is "deeply mistaken". Tehran calls "no-war, no-peace" unacceptable.	"Much broader" retaliation

Viewpoint	How they frame it	Key words
Russia	Russia deepened military support, per the FT, with a missile-launcher deal.	Arms deal
Gulf and Arab	Mediators say Hormuz could reopen within days if the blockade lifts.	Mediation
Markets and analysts	Priced a deal, though Eurasia Group reportedly puts the odds at 10%.	"Binary"

Disputed: The IRGC's claim that two tankers hit mines has no independent confirmation. No text has been signed.

US-China trade and technology

View point	How they frame it	Key words
US	Bessent says Beijing must meet its commitments "immediately". US intelligence alleges a link between Jensen Huang and a Chinese asset.	"Immediately", espionage
China	The Commerce Ministry reserves the right to retaliate. The foreign ministry dismissed the Huang reports.	Retaliation, "dismissed"
Europe	Berlin presses on the export surplus. ABB shows the risk of Chinese deal vetoes.	Surplus, security review
Nvidia	Calls the contacts routine business.	"Routine"

Agreed: Both sides are tightening tech controls. **Disputed:** whether China is under-delivering, and whether Huang knew of any espionage (nobody is charged).

Trends of the Week

Energy inflation turns into a global tightening cycle

Euro-area inflation is 4.0%, the Bank of England has hiked to 4.00%, and the Fed held on 28 October with two dissenters wanting a hike. The Bank of Japan says its 2% goal is met and signals a possible December hike. Central banks that expected to cut are now debating how much to raise.

The common cause is the Iran war and the closure of Hormuz. Brent was about $72 before the war. Markets are cutting that risk premium on hopes of a deal, but no deal exists. Policy is therefore running on prices that may reverse.

The AI trade meets politics

A boom financed by debt and heavy capital spending hit two doubts at once: whether returns justify the spending, and whether a Democratic Congress will make data centres harder to build. Local ballot measures also largely went against the industry. Money is rotating to Chinese and Indian stocks, to cheaper sectors, and to gold, up 4.5% on the week.

Power is a second pressure point. Anthropic signed a $3.4bn gas-power deal, and residents protest data centres in Indonesia and Malaysia.

Europe's security is being negotiated without Europe

The Abu Dhabi talks, the Kushner-linked plan, a NATO aid shortfall of €7bn and the end of US military aid to Israel point the same way: Washington is reshaping alliances through deals and not treaties. Europeans respond with exercises, such as the 2,800-troop drill in Poland, and with defence projects like the interceptor consortium choice due by end-November. Hybrid attacks from the cyberattack on Tajani to flight hoaxes show Russia testing Europe below the threshold of war.

Economic security replaces free trade

Rare-earth licences, Nvidia's China exposure, Beijing's ABB veto, Putin's seizure of Japan Tobacco's Russian business, and US sanctions that may cut the ICC off from dollar settlements all show finance and supply chains used as weapons. Japan's 28 priority sectors for ¥370 trillion are a state-led answer.

A divided Washington, a retreating West

The midterms produce a Congress able to investigate but not to override vetoes. The UN's departure from Western Sahara and the Rwanda sanctions show how great-power vetoes and US pressure decide African outcomes. China fills gaps: it sent $132bn of clean tech to developing countries last year.

Deep Dive

The energy shock that turned into a rate cycle

Background. Before the Iran war, central banks were close to done with tightening. The war began about nine months ago and closed the Strait of Hormuz, through which a large share of the world's oil and LNG (liquefied natural gas) passes. Brent rose from about $72 to over $115. Dutch TTF gas, Europe's benchmark, topped €100/MWh in late October, a four-year high. EU storage was only 74.6% full on 25 October against a five-year average near 86%.

The actors. The ECB must control inflation without crushing economies that are already weak. It hiked in June and September and held the deposit rate at 2.50% on 29 October. Governing Council hawks warn markets may underestimate the tightening needed. Lagarde says inflation will stay high near term and second-round effects (energy feeding wages and other prices) are no worse than expected. The Bank of England has hiked, and the Fed's two dissenters wanted a hike. A strong US jobs report (165,000 against about 65,000 expected) raises the stakes.

What changed this week. October inflation rose to 4.0%, with Italy at 5.6%, France 3.8%, Spain 4.9% and Germany 2.8% (helped by a temporary fuel-tax cut). Core inflation is 2.5%, so the pressure is still

mostly energy. Then oil fell 16% in a week. That drop rests on reports of diplomacy, not on any reopening. Washington, Tehran and the IRGC (Iran's Revolutionary Guards) claimed more mine attacks on tankers, and Iran's leadership rejects softening. Eurasia Group reportedly sees a deal at 10%.

The ECB also faces a leadership change. Lagarde leaves on 7 February 2027. Knot is seen as slightly more hawkish and Hernández de Cos as slightly more dovish, with modest differences. A Knot win would require Dutchman Frank Elderson to leave the ECB board. A late surprise entrant is still possible, as Lagarde herself was in 2019.

Italy and Europe. Italy is the most exposed large economy. Inflation is above the euro-area average, wages lag, and Q3 GDP was flat. The Commission's spring forecast put 2026 growth at 0.5%. The 2027 budget of about €26bn leans on EU approval of a €29bn deviation across 2027-28, and about 85% of the extra €10.9bn for defence and security falls in those years. A December hike would add to debt-service costs and to the cost of floating-rate mortgages. Yet the spread has held near 113 basis points, well below 131 on 1 October. Strong bank earnings, such as Intesa's, help.

How it could evolve. There are three paths.

- **Deal:** a Hormuz reopening lowers gas and oil, inflation peaks, and the ECB could skip December. Wage settlements stay moderate.
- **Stalemate:** prices stay near $95-105, and the ECB hikes to 2.75% in December on 17 December. This is the market's central case.
- **Escalation:** strikes resume or shipping is hit, Brent rises towards $120, and further hikes follow. Combined with an AI sell-off and French fiscal stress, the periphery would suffer first.

Three dates give the earliest signals: US inflation on 10 November, the Abu Dhabi talks, and the Commission's autumn forecast expected mid-November.

Market Implications of the Week

Asset or sector	Pressure	Driver	Already priced in?
US tech, AI, chipmakers	Down	Midterm result, data-centre scrutiny, valuation doubts; Nasdaq 100 down 4.91% on the week	Partly; sentiment shifted, long-term build-out unclear
Japan and Korea equities	Down	Memory-chip exposure; Nikkei down 11.17% on the week	Partly, after the biggest drop since April 2025
European equities (FTSE MIB 50,053, +1.12%)	Mixed	Banks up, defence down	Partly
Brent and WTI	Down	Hopes of a US-Iran deal; Brent $98.32	Largely a binary bet; no deal signed
Dutch gas (TTF, about €85/MWh)	Down, with an upside risk	Hormuz hopes against low storage	Partly
Gold ($4,075)	Up	Risk-off, geopolitics	Partly
Dollar and US yields	Up	Strong jobs; 10-year at 4.86%	Partly
BTP spread (about 113)	Mixed	Risk-off against bank strength	Largely
Chinese and Indian equities	Up	Rotation out of AI; state support	Uncertain
Bitcoin ($75,871)	Down	Weaker US regulatory tailwind	Partly

Themes for next week

- **US CPI on 10 November:** a hot print would raise Fed and ECB hike odds and add to pressure on tech valuations.
- **Abu Dhabi and Hormuz:** oil has priced a deal. Headlines can reverse it quickly.

- **AI follow-through:** the VIX at 25.6 shows stress. Watch Democratic statements on data centres and Asian chip stocks.
- **ECB succession and Italian spreads:** a hawkish nominee or higher-for-longer signals matter for BTP pricing.

Market Opportunities & Risks

This is general education, not advice. The themes below describe what is moving markets and what could go wrong. They are not recommendations.

AI valuations meet politics

Drivers: Heavy AI spending, new doubts about returns and the prospect of tougher scrutiny of data centres under a Democratic Congress. **Exposed:** US mega-cap tech, chipmakers (especially Korea and Taiwan), and index funds that hold them heavily. **Risks:** A fall already near 5% on the Nasdaq 100 for the week, with high volatility (VIX 25.6). **Horizon and pricing:** Short-term sentiment is clearly shifting. Whether the long-term AI build-out is "priced in" is unclear.

Energy-driven inflation and rate hikes

Drivers: Euro-area inflation of 4.0%, a BoE hike and a Fed leaning hawkish. **Exposed:** Government and corporate bonds, mortgages, rate-sensitive sectors such as housing. **Risks:** Rates stay higher for longer. Markets are pricing possible further tightening in the US and the euro area. **Horizon:** Months.

Oil as a bet on diplomacy

Drivers: Brent fell 16% on hopes of a US–Iran deal that does not yet exist. **Exposed:** Energy producers, airlines, chemicals, and fuel-heavy consumers. **Risks:** Two-way. Tanker attacks or failed talks push prices up, while a deal pushes them down further. **Pricing:** Largely a binary outcome.

Safe havens and the dollar

Drivers: Gold gained 4.5% to about $4,075 and the dollar firmed. **Exposed:** Gold and silver funds, currencies, euro-based investors holding dollar assets. **Risks:** Gold can fall quickly if real yields rise or tensions ease.

Rotation to Asia ex-tech

Drivers: Nifty +6.6% and Hang Seng +5.1%, helped by China's market support. **Risks:** State-driven rallies can fade, and US–China trade friction is unresolved.

Credit and crypto fragilities

Junk-bond stress (Arini) and a less friendly US regulatory climate for crypto are early warning signs. Bitcoin fell 1.9% on the week.

Investing basics

Bond prices move opposite to yields. When central banks raise rates, existing bonds paying lower rates become less attractive, so their prices fall. Longer-dated bonds fall more, which is called duration risk. A bond held to maturity still pays its face value, but the price on the way can swing.

Scenario Scorecard

What played out

- **Midterms:** the base case (Democrats take the House) held, and the Senate went further than expected. Trump accepted the result but raised the stakes with Miller.
- **AI sell-off (31 October scenario):** the base case of continued volatility was exceeded. The Nasdaq 100 fell 6.3% in a day, and a mere "repricing of AI debt" turned into a political story.
- **BTP spread:** the 110-130 range held at about 113.
- **Iran:** the 30 October base case (Brent $105-120, no major strike before the vote) was half right. No strike came, but Brent fell to $98 on hope. We underweighted market anticipation of a deal.

- **ECB:** the 4 November scenario of a December hold was overtaken. Lagarde's remarks and 4.0% inflation made a hike the central case.
- **Ukraine talks:** the base case that they resume without breakthrough is on track. They open on 10 November.
- **Ex Ilva (Federacciai):** the outcome is not confirmed in our reporting.

What we learned: Markets move ahead of diplomacy, and political causes of sell-offs are usually mixed.

Going into next week

1. **Abu Dhabi:** *Base:* talks produce humanitarian steps and no ceasefire. *Upside:* an energy-strike pause. *Downside:* a US-Russia understanding Europeans reject.
2. **Iran and oil:** *Base:* no signed deal and Brent $90-105. *Upside:* a text and partial Hormuz reopening. *Downside:* strikes resume and Brent rises above $110.
3. **Rates:** *Base:* US CPI and the Eurogroup keep a December ECB hike in play. *Upside:* a soft CPI. *Downside:* a hot CPI plus a hawkish ECB pick lifts the spread.

Explained

The BTP-Bund spread

It is the gap between the yield on Italy's 10-year bond (BTP) and Germany's equivalent (Bund). Germany is the euro area's benchmark safe borrower, so the gap measures extra risk. Investors compare yields. When they fear for Italy, they demand a higher yield, and the spread widens. It is quoted in basis points, where 100 basis points is one percentage point. Think of it as the extra interest a bank charges a riskier borrower. This week it was 113.83 on 3 November, against 131 on 1 October and about 88-89 in September. **Key number: 113 basis points.**

The ECB deposit rate and second-round effects

The ECB's deposit rate is the interest banks earn on cash parked at the central bank. It anchors what banks charge on loans and mortgages. Raising it slows borrowing and demand. The ECB worries about second-round effects: energy price jumps spreading into wages and prices

elsewhere. It is like a fire: the first blaze is oil and gas, while the second is people demanding higher wages. Core inflation (2.5%) is the test. **Key number: 2.50%, with 2.75% possible on 17 December.**

The national escape clause

EU fiscal rules limit deficits to 3% of GDP. A country over the line can be in an excessive deficit procedure (EDP). The escape clause lets governments temporarily deviate from spending paths for specific reasons, such as defence. Rome has asked to use it for defence and energy, and finance ministers decide around 9 November. It works like a household negotiating a one-off exemption for a big repair. **Key number: €29bn deviation across 2027-28.**

The VIX and a leverage unwind

The VIX gauges expected volatility in US stocks over 30 days, derived from options prices. A rise signals fear. A leverage unwind is when investors who borrowed to buy assets are forced to sell as prices fall, which deepens the fall. Some analysts use that to explain this week's drop, which is a view, not a fact. **Key number: VIX 25.64, up 32% on the week.**

Week Ahead

Date	Event	Why it matters
Mon 9 Nov	Eurogroup reviews ECB president nominees (Knot, Hernández de Cos); Italy's escape-clause request expected around this date	Starts the Lagarde succession. EU leaders decide later.
Tue 10 Nov	Italy's national public-security committee at the Viminale	Italy's response to the cyber threat after the Tajani leak
Tue 10 Nov	US October CPI, 8:30 ET (14:30 Italy)	Shapes Fed and ECB hike bets and tech valuations
Tue 10 Nov	China's October trade data (date per desk report, not verified)	Gauges the surplus and exports, before Trump-Xi meetings

Date	Event	Why it matters
10-11 Nov	US-Russia-Ukraine talks in Abu Dhabi	First three-way talks since February; Europe is absent
Wed 11 Nov	OPEC monthly report	Demand and supply view after the oil drop
Thu 12 Nov	Sun Yat-sen's 160th birthday	China and Taiwan contest his legacy
Mid-Nov (date unconfirmed)	Commission autumn forecast	Italian growth and deficit checkpoint
Just beyond	16 Nov Belgium budget report; 18 Nov final euro-area inflation, House briefing on Huang; 18-19 Nov APEC Shenzhen	Next week's build-up

Glossary

- **Basis point:** one hundredth of a percentage point.
- **BTP:** Italian government bond.
- **Bund:** German government bond, the euro-area benchmark.
- **ECB:** European Central Bank, which sets euro-area interest rates.
- **Eurogroup:** Euro-area finance ministers. They review the ECB nominees.
- **Brent:** Benchmark oil price for Europe.
- **TTF:** Dutch gas price, Europe's benchmark.
- **Hormuz:** Strait carrying a large share of Gulf oil and LNG.
- **IRGC:** Iran's Revolutionary Guards.
- **Busan truce:** Trump-Xi trade pause of 30 October 2025.
- **Rare earths:** Metals used in magnets for cars and weapons.
- **APEC:** Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation summit, in Shenzhen.
- **DSA:** Digital Services Act, the EU platform law used against TikTok.
- **MINURSO:** UN mission in Western Sahara, now ended.
- **Noname057(16):** Pro-Russian hacker group that targeted Italy.

- **VIX:** Wall Street's volatility gauge.

Sources: BLS CPI schedule, Eunews, Euronews

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